case, continued Malinovsky, “If an invasion of Cuba is declared, this will be after another 24 hours have passed in order to get ready. I think that we will not end up in a situation in which the missiles are placed on high alert.”

Malinovsky was followed by General Ivanov, the secretary of the Defense Council, who reported on the state of the Soviet armed forces in Cuba: more than forty thousand officers and soldiers were already on the island; three of the four R-12 regiments, with their missiles and equipment, were taking their positions, as were those in charge of the Luna tactical nuclear weapons and the nuclear warheads. The R-14 regiments and their equipment were still en route.[7]

Khrushchev backed his minister of defense: for the moment there was no reason to put the strategic missiles on high alert. “The point is that we do not want to unleash a war,” he told his colleagues. “We want to intimidate and restrain the USA vis-à-vis Cuba.” Mikoyan and others had heard those assurances before, but now it was a very different situation—the Americans had probably discovered the missiles, and the initiative had been taken out of Khrushchev’s hands. Khrushchev admitted that the American announcement had taken him by surprise. “The difficult thing is,” continued the Soviet leader, “that we did not consolidate all that we wanted and did not publish the treaty with Cuba.” And then he mentioned what was probably on everyone’s mind—the danger of uncontrolled escalation of the conflict. “The tragic thing is,” said Khrushchev, according to the brief protocol of the meeting, “that they can attack, and we will respond. This could escalate into a large-scale war.”

Khrushchev was convinced that the American invasion of Cuba was in the making. “Conclusion (is being made): An attack is being organized against Cuba,” reads one of the lines in the terse protocol of the meeting. The question was what Kennedy’s next step would be. “They might declare a blockade, or they might take no action,” speculated Khrushchev or one of his colleagues. No action required no response. But in case an attack should take place, they considered two scenarios. “One scenario: declare on the radio that there already is an agreement concerning Cuba,” reads the protocol of the meeting. Such an announcement was supposed to serve as a warning to the Americans that escalation of the conflict would lead to a direct confrontation with the Soviet Union. Khrushchev’s other option—the